Nailing PM Interviews

Getting the desired job

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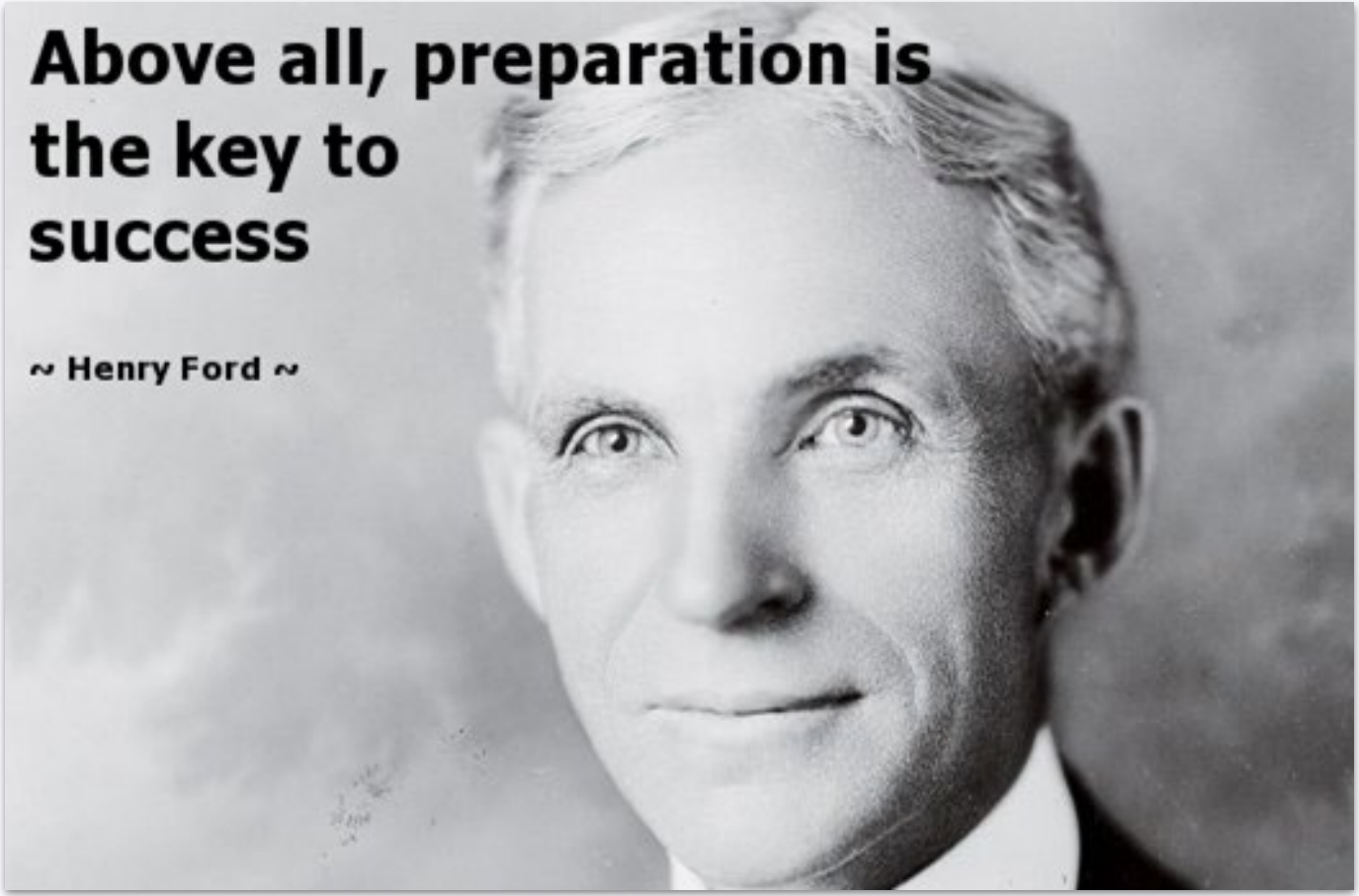
But first, Recap

Cultivating Product Culture

- Good product culture generate better products and work processes
- Product Culture is comprised of many different building blocks
- Not all blocks are suitable for all companies
- Try to implement as many as these blocks
- Use this list to locate blind spots in your company

Agenda

1. Behavioral Questions
2. Product Sensing Questions
3. Product Execution Questions
4. Product Strategy Questions
5. Interview preparations



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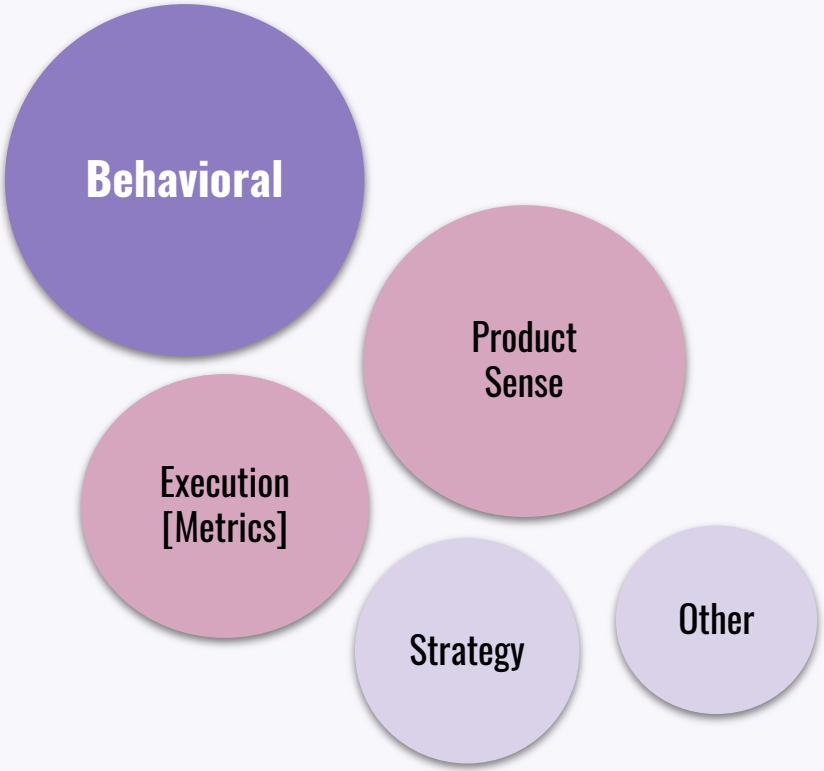
The Interview Questions



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Behavioral Questions

Behavioral Questions // Tell me about a time…

Leadership / Influence

- Describe a decision you made that wasn’t popular. How did you handle implementing it?
- Tell me about a time when you showed initiative
- Tell me about a time when you had to sell another person or team on your idea

Teamwork

- Tell me about a time when you had to work across teams to accomplish something
- Tell me about a time when you had a disagreement at work
- Tell me about a time you worked with a difficult team member

Behavioral Questions // Type of questions - Cont’

Successes

- Tell me about something you’re proud of accomplishing
- Tell me about a time when you reached a goal that was important

Challenges

- Tell me about a time when you faced a challenge and overcame it
- Tell me about a time when you weren’t able to reach a deadline

Mistakes /Failures

- Tell me about a time when you made a mistake
- Tell me about a time when you failed

Behavioral Questions // Follow-up questions

- How did the team react?
- How did this affect the future of the team?
- What did you learn from this?
- What would you do differently if this situation came up again?
- Do you always handle situations like this? If not, what made you handle things this way this time?

Behavioral Questions // Structure

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Behavioral questions preparation

- For each story -
  - What are my strengths in the story?
  - What is my message from the story
- Think about the skills you want to empathize because they are missing in your resume
  - e.g. how you're making a decision based on data

creative	scrappy	analytical
decisive	organized	energetic
calm under pressure	risk taking	thinking outside the box
understand people's feelings	see things through	thorough
detail-oriented	initiative	flexible
multitasking	quantitative	good planner
persistent	good at taking feedback	leadership
independent	data-driven	persuasive
not afraid of challenges	good mentor; caring	self-critical
add humor and fun to a team	enjoy learning new skills	prioritization

“Tell me about a time when you had to work across teams to accomplish something”

Let’s exercise…

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Behavioral Questions // Structure example

“Tell me about a time when you had to influence a team”

- Nugget: Sure, let me tell you about the time I needed to cut the scope of a project.
- Situation: To meet an important release deadline, we needed to cut a key feature. Unfortunately, this was a feature the developers were particularly excited about. If I just came out and told them, “Sorry, but no,” they'd be demoralized and feel that their opinion wasn't valued.
- Action: I identified two developers as being particularly strong influencers, one because she was very senior and the other because he was very well liked. I focused on getting them on board with the decision first.
- I met with the senior dev first to discuss the impending deadline and what it meant for the product's architecture. We discussed options and consequences, and ultimately she arrived at the same conclusion: we needed to cut this feature.
- With the other developer, I told him about the discussion with the senior dev, appealing to this dev on more of an emotional level. I knew he valued his social status on the team, so I told him how much his support on this would mean to me. He shared his concerns about the team's reaction and assured me that he would support me.
- I asked both developers to help me present the decision to the team.
- Result: The team was ultimately disappointed in the conclusion but sympathetic. Hearing two highly valued team members back the decision, they trusted that it was the right one. I pledged to them that, if we could push forward to get this release done ASAP, we'd start working on this feature right after that release.
- We ended up making the deadline with a day to spare and then getting that other feature out a few weeks later

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Let’s practice

Think about a good project you lead / successful interaction and write the story in the STAR framework

+What you Learned!

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These are the questions you can and should be the MOST prepared for,

DO NOT cut corners!

Product Sensing Questions

Product Sense Questions

- The goal is to see how you're approaching big product challenge
  - How you define **goals**
  - How you understand the **problems** for different groups of users
  - How you come up with **creative solutions**
  - How you **prioritize**
- Questions type:
  1. How would you design/redesign product X?
  2. How would you improve product Y?
  3. Favorite product

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Product Sense // Design a New Product

- How would you design _____?
  - Design a social travel app
  - Design a product for pet lovers
  - Design an alarm clock for the blind
  - How would you redesign a microwave?
  - How would you design a gardening app?
  - Design an umbrella for kids
  - Design a phone for deaf people

Product Sense // Design a New Product

- Step 1: Ask questions to clarify the scope of question
  - Which platform?
  - Type of user group
  - Any objective to keep in mind?
  - Do you understand what the interviewer is asking about?
- Step 2: Provide a structure
- Step 3: Define a goal/mission
- Step 4: Identify the user groups and select one
  - Explain why you selected this user group (size, pain, etc.)
- Step 5: List user needs/pains
  - You can write down the user journey
  - Take time to think
- Step 6: Prioritize pain points
  - Size of pain
  - Impact on user
  - Revenue potential
- Step 7: List solutions
  - Take time to think
  - Mix of creative and practical
  - Try to come up with 3 at minimum
- Step 8: Evaluate and prioritize solutions
  - Value & cost
- Step 9: Risks & tradeoffs
- Step 10: Describe MVP
- Step 11: Metrics to measure success

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Example // “Design an app for the DMV”

- Step 1: Ask questions to clarify the scope of question
  - Mobile/web?
  - Any goal in mind?
- Step 2: Provide a structure
- Step 3: Define a goal/mission
  - Make the DMV experience seamless
- Step 4: Identify the user groups
  - Citizense
  - DMV agents
  - DMV officers (enforce law)
- Step 5: List user needs/pains
  - Get a ticket and wait in line when physically arriving to the DMV
  - Forget to bring some needed documents
  - Need to wait for the documents to be processed (might take a few days)
  - Need to pay a fee - how can they pay?
- Step 6: Prioritize pain points
  - Have to get a ticket and wait in line when physically arriving to the DMV - waste of time and annoying
  - Forget to bring some needed documents - very common and very painful

Example // “Design an app for the DMV” - Cont’

- Step 7: List solutions
  - App that will allow you to select type of visit and get a list or required documents and processing time
  - App that will allow to pre-submit documents
  - App that will manage a queue and tell users when to leave home
- Step 8: Evaluate and prioritize solutions
  - App that will allow you to select type of visit and get a list or required documents and processing time - gives value with very low effort (you may not even need the DMV involvement)
- Step 9: Risks & tradeoffs
  - We may need to involve the DMV to be accurate / useful - can delay dev time
- Step 10: Describe MVP
  - A user will need to sign up. There will be an option to select a type of visit and get all the info about it. User will also have general info about hours of operations, locations, etc.
- Step 10: Metrics
  - App downloads
  - App sign-ups
  - App rating

Product Sense // Improve a Product

- What would you improve about _____?
  - Improve FB birthdays
  - How would you improve Google Maps?
  - How would you improve coffee machines used in offices?
  - Pick your favorite app. How would you improve it?

Product Sense // Improve a Product

What is different?

- Step 0: Describe the product
- Step 1: Ask questions to clarify the scope of question
  - Would you consider this product a mature product or still in the growth phase?
- Step 3: Choose a goal
  - Improve revenues
  - Increase engagement
  - Improve retention
  - Increase adoption

Product Sense // Favorite product

Think about 3 products you like and know well (At least one that is not super well known) and prepare answers

Structure:

- Describe the product
  - What problem does it solve/goal?
  - Who are the main users?
  - What are the user needs?
  - Why is it better than the competitors?
  - KPIs
- Favorite features
- Missing features

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Product Sense // CIRCLES method

Comprehend the situation (ask questions; context)

Identify the users

Report users needs and pains

Cut through prioritization

List solutions

Evaluate tradeoffs

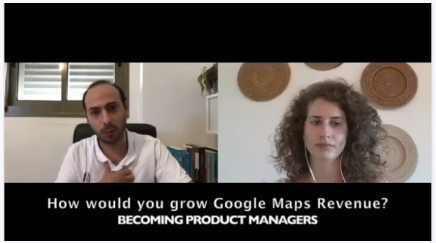
Summerize your recommendation

Product Sense // Tips

- There is no ‘correct answer’ here!
- Show you can lead product discussion and brainstorm
- Have an opinion
- Use the whiteboard / paper
- Take time (2 mins) to structure your answer or think about pains/solutions
- Ask questions (not too much)
- Look at the mission for help with prioritization

Product Design // How to prepare?

Mock interviews



Prep-websites

- Exponent
- Product Management Exercises

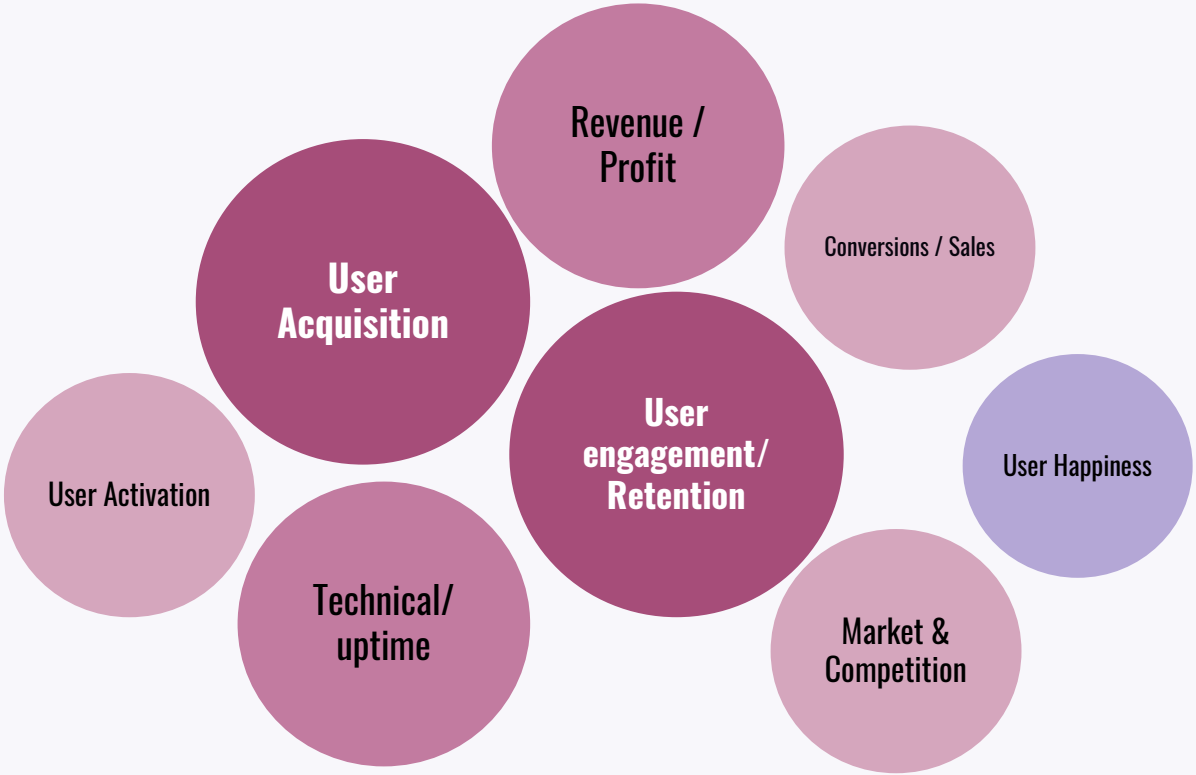
Product Execution [Metrics] Questions

Product Metrics

- The goal is to see if you can define success, prioritize, and debug issues, as well as measure your product's success and health.

- Questions:
  1. What would be the success metrics for product A / What goal you want to set?
  2. What KPIs you would look at for product Y?
  3. You have recognized a drop in metric Z, what could be the root cause?

Product Success Metrics



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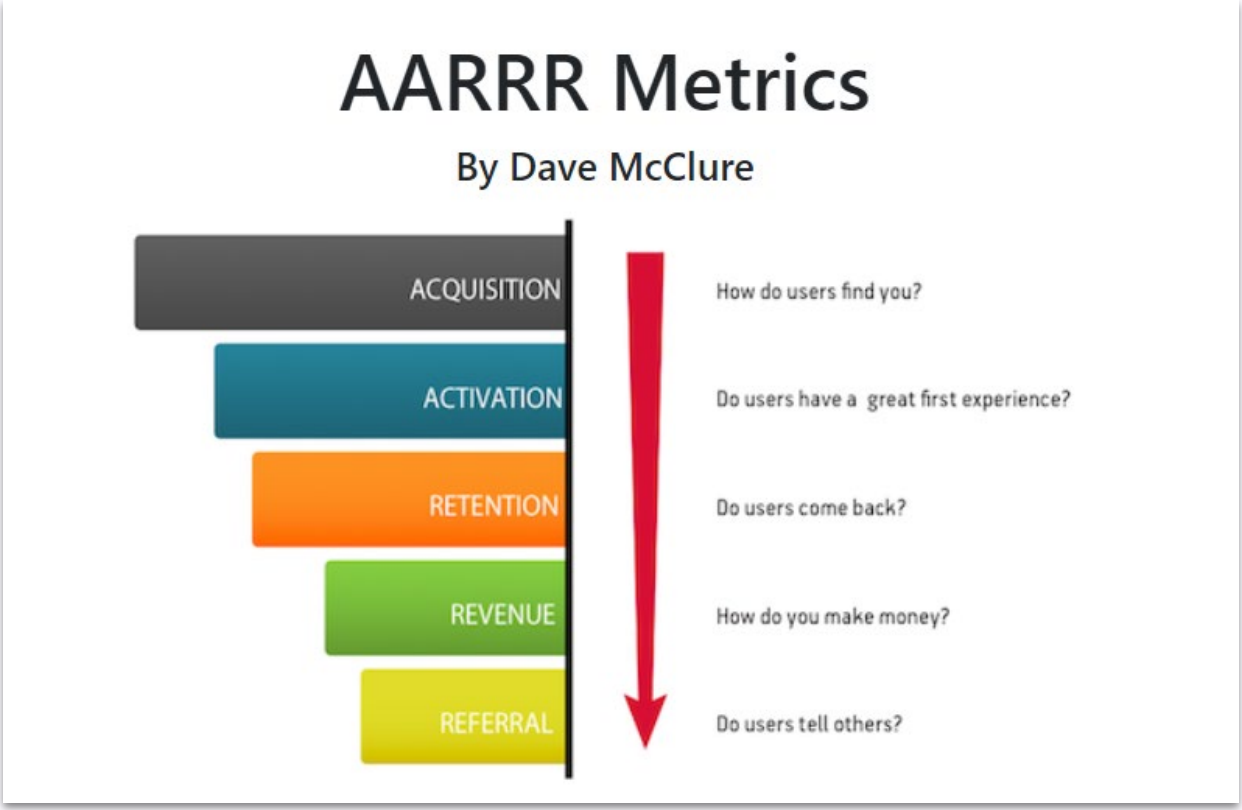
Frameworks - AARRR



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Product Metrics // Sample Questions

- If you were the PM for the Groups Feature at Facebook, what metrics would you use to define the success of this feature?
- What metrics you would look at as a product manager for Instagram ads?
- You are the product manager for Airbnb Experiences. What goals will you set for your team? What north star goal will you use?
- Define the metrics for YouTube search.
- How would you prioritize between presenting “people you may know” and ads to users?
- Weekly active users (WAU) for iPhone app dropped. What happened?
- Friend requests are down by 10%. Evaluate why.

Product Metrics // Success Metrics

- Step 1: Describe the product
  - You may need to narrow down the scope and choose an area to focus on
  - Ask clarifying questions if needed
- Step 2: Provide a structure
- Step 3: Define a goal of this feature
- Step 4: Map the user journey
- Step 5: List metrics based on **user journey** or by **category/Framework** (Awareness, Acquisition, Activation, Engagement, Retention, Monetization, Referral)
- Step 6: Evaluate metrics
  - Relevance to mission
  - Value to user
  - Confidence in accuracy
  - Effort to collect
- Step 7: Prioritize metrics
  - North-star metric
  - Top level metrics
  - Other metrics
- Step 8: Risks
  - What you are not capturing with these prioritized metrics?

Product Metrics // Debugging

- Step 1: Understand the problem statement
- Step 2: Ask questions to root cause the problem
  - Any specific platform?
  - Any specific geography?
  - Any specific operating system?
  - Time it happened. For how long?
  - Any type of users?
  - Any product change?
  - Any reported bugs?
  - Any action by competitors?
- Step 3: present an hypothesis
- Step 4: Suggest an action

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Product Metrics // Tips

- Learn the metrics that this company is using
- Learn the particular industry standards
- Learn their product and think in advance on their KPIs and measurements
- Watch mock interviews and practice
  - https://www.tryexponent.com/courses/analytical/mock-interview-metrics-facebook-events
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=z0qUkteC2os

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Product Metrics // E-Commerce

Acquisition

- Daily sessions
- Cost per acquisition (CPA)
- Cost per click (CPC)
- Cost per impression (CPM)
- Top search engine terms leading to website
- Mailing list click through rate
- Mailing list open rate
- Mailing list conversion rate
- Mobile app downloads

Activation

- New registered users
- Mobile app opens
- Number of searches on website or app
- New cart started
- User information given (address, credit card, etc.)
- New customers with successful purchase

Retention

- Conversion rate
- Recommendation engine conversion rate
- Shopping cart abandonment
- Shopping cart size

Monetization

- Revenue per customer
- Lapsed customers
- Purchases per year
- Revenue per click
- Cost of sale (ad spend / revenue)
- Customer lifetime value (CLV)
- Cost of shipping

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Product Metrics // Marketplace

Marketplace Metrics, Buy Side

Acquisition

- Mobile app downloads

Activation

- Users with at least 1 search

Retention

- Searches
- Searches with 1+ Matches
- CTR for search result
- Percent satisfied transactions
- Net promoter score

Monetization

- Revenue
- Avg. transaction size
- Number of transactions

Marketplace Metrics, Sell Side

Acquisition

- Sellers
- Seller growth rate

Activation

- Sellers with at least 1 listing

Retention

- Listings per seller
- Net promoter score

Monetization

- Gross marketplace volume
- Percent fraudulent transactions

Other

- Seller concentration, that is percent of revenue generated by the top X percent of sellers
- Marketplace as a percent of overall channel sales

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Product Metrics // Mobile App

Acquisition

- Number of mobile installs
- Cost per install

Activation

- Number of accounts created, after mobile download

Retention

- Daily and monthly active usage
- Time in app
- Star rating
- Session length
- Percent of users that rate the app

Monetization

- Percent that are paid users
- Lifetime value
- Average revenue per user
- Churn

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Product Metrics // Support Ticket

- Number of customer tickets
- Number of customer tickets by type, including email, call, or chat
- Average resolution time
- Concern classification
- Net promoter score
- First call resolution
- Average number of calls per resolution

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Product Metrics // Uber Metrics

Acquisition

- Total app downloads

Activation

- Total signups
- % of signups with payment information
- % of signups with at least one ride request
- % of smartphone users who have tried Uber at least once

Retention

- # of Uber customers that open the app and do not see Uber cars in the area (aka zeroes)
- # of requests for an Uber car
- # of completed trips
- Completed trips / Requested trips
- # of rides per month per customer
- DAU, WAU, and MAU
- Miles per ride
- % cancelled trips
- Average driver rating
- % rides with surge pricing
- Median arrival times

Monetization

- Total revenue, by market
- Average fare per trip
- Average fare per driver hour
- Active drivers
- Service hours
- Service hours per driver
- Service hours per driver per day
- Total trips
- Trips per driver
- Trips per driver per day
- Uber's service fee percentage

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Product Strategy Questions

Product Strategy

- The product strategy questions are meant to assess your ability to:
  - Have a structured thinking process in dealing with abstract situations
  - Comprehend a company's strengths and weaknesses
  - Determine strategic choices for the company and the product
  - Carefully analyze and evaluate pros and cons of your options from various aspects
  - Make a meaningful executive decision that considers all the key aspects of the decision

- Questions:
  - Market analysis (should Amazon enter the airline tickets engin business?)
  - Go-to-market strategy (we decided to launch Kindle in Kenya, how should we do it?)
  - Product growth / revenue growth / business growth (How would you grow Netflix revenues?)
  - Trade-offs

Product Strategy // Sample Questions

- What should be Airbnb's strategy during the Covid-19 pandemic?
- How would you monetize Facebook Messenger?
- Why do you think Microsoft bought LinkedIn?
- If you were the CEO of LEGO, what new product line would you come up with to increase revenue?
- You are a PM at Uber. Devise strategies to improve revenue.
- Should Google get into the ticketing market?
- Why should Facebook enter the dating market?

Product Strategy // Structure

- Step 1: Clarify the question
  - Why do we want to enter this market?
  - Is there a problem with the current business model?
  - Should I think about revenues or adoption?
- Step 2: Describe the company & product
  - Make sure you are on the same page
  - SWOT
- Step 3: List your strategic choices
  - Sometimes given in the question (trade-offs)
  - Think what can be interesting considering the company and market conditions
- Step 4: List your evaluation criteria/framework
  - UX, revenue, execution, effort
  - Customer, Company, Competitors
- Step 5: Evaluate each strategic choice
  - Pros and cons of each strategic choice
  - Be critical
- Step 6: Make a recommendation

Product Strategy // Trade-offs Example

Amazon launched display advertisements on its web page, and it was a highly controversial decision within the company. Pick either the pro or con side of the argument and explain your position for or against including ads on the site.

Product Strategy // Trade-offs Example

Launching Amazon display advertisements is a **good decision** and there are two reasons why:

1. **It helps customer experience**. Advertisements can minimize negative customer experiences and possibly enhance a positive customer experience. Let's say a customer was intent on buying a product, but Amazon is out of stock. The customer was going to leave the site anyway. Amazon can direct the consumer to a competitor that does have the product, enhancing the customer experience. Alternatively, advertising can highlight special offers, enhancing the Amazon shopping experience.

2. **It provides additional revenue**. Advertisers will pay Amazon to achieve the advertiser's business goals. For instance, manufacturers might want to increase awareness, increase up sell, or shift share away from competitor's products.
   There's even an opportunity to sell ads to Amazon's competitors. Amazon's competitors may be too happy to meet an Amazon customers unmet purchase needs. The latter case may feel bizarre, but there is a revenue opportunity, along with an opportunity for improved customer satisfaction. This revenue can be used to further invest in the Amazon customer experience.

Product Strategy // Trade-offs Example

Launching display advertisements on Amazon are a **bad decision**, and here's why:

1. **Distracts customers from purchasing products**. Ads can clutter the customer experience. For example, it may be harder for the customer to find what they want. In the short-term, it could lead to increased bounce rates, more abandoned shopping carts and reduced conversions. In the long-term, it could lead to fewer repeat visits as customers search for shopping alternatives that are less cluttered and frustrating.
2. **Create a negative brand perception.** Over time, customers could notice that Amazon repeatedly refers customers to other retailers. Rather than come to Amazon as their first shopping destination, they may choose to go to those retailers first. This will give the competitor an opportunity to establish their reputation as the first place to find & research products they need.

Product Strategy // New Markets

- Market characteristics
  - Market size
  - Market growth
  - Profit margins
  - Market trends, including changing customer preferences and regulatory changes
- Competitive environment
  - Number of competitors
  - Competitor’s resources, including financial, employees, and partner ecosystem
  - Competitor’s unique competencies, including differentiated products, access to distribution channels
- Company fit
  - Expertise
  - Economies of scale
  - Access to distribution channels
  - Good relationships with suppliers
  - Related to existing brand promise
- Customers
  - Purchase power
  - Language
  - Habits

Other Questions

Walk me through your resume

- ~4 mins; Be prepared with a solid pitch about your:
  - Background, Accomplishments, Interests
- **Don't**
  - Read off your resume
  - Talk too much about personal life (help them not to be biased)
  - Be boring
- **Do**:
  - Connect your experience with the job you're interviewing for
  - Sell yourself
  - Be memorable
  - Be passionate and proud of your past work
  - Start from the relevant part (first or last job)

Why are you leaving your current job?

Don’t

- Complain about your current role
- Focus on money
- Being bored and not learning

Do

- Focus on the positive
- Show what you’ve learned

Examples:

- “After being a development manager for several years, I’ve acquired deep technology and leadership experience. I now want to take those skills to move more into the product management side, since I really love the experience of launching a new product.”

- “I actually really like my current company and role, but after being there for several years, I want to be somewhere which is giving more back to the world.”

Strengths & Weaknesses

Strengths

- “Tell me about your top 3 strengths”
- Prepare 3-4 strengths and think about examples that demonstrate them

Growth Areas / Weakness

- “Tell me about your weaknesses”
- Prepare 2-3 weakness
- Think about REAL weakness but make sure they will not hurt the job
- Explain what you do to improve these areas or overcome your weaknesses
- Make sure you can “turn them around” to a good thing

Company Specific

- Why do you want to work for us?
  - Think about what is unique about the company
  - Think about examples how this company relates to your values / impacted your life for the good
  - Network and try to learn about the company from current employees
- Research if the company has specific questions it tends to ask and prepare for it
  - Amazon - Leadership principles

Interview Preparations

Before the Interview // Research

- **Company**
  - Vision/mission, size & scale, B2C/B2B, products, financial reports/shareholders letters (if available)
- **Market**
  - Industry trends, competitors, articles
- **Product**
  - Try the product
  - YouTube manuals / demos
  - Forums
  - Reviews
  - KPIs

Before the Interview // Research - Cont.

- **Interviewer**
  - Resume, blogpost and public materials, social profiles
  - Prepare thoughtful questions!!
- **Do**:
  - READ - website, FB & Linkedin pages, company/product/R&D blog posts, articles
  - Network - friends who work there, people you know at similar positions
  - Look for common questions - friends that were interviewed to this positions, Glassdoor, FB groups

Key Takeaways

- Nailing an interview is all about preparation
- You can get prepared for the vast majority of the questions
- Training makes perfection
- Learn about the company you're interviewing for, and the industry
- Prepare, prepare, prepare!

Thank You

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